

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Yoga - Learner-v2

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Yoga

English-first concept spine • Sanskrit/Pali IAST follows in parentheses

- 1 mind-field (citta)
- 2 mental modifications (citta-vṛttis)
- 3 afflictions (kleśas)
- 4 meditative absorption (samādhi)
- 5 isolation (kaivalya)
- 6 eight-limbed discipline (aṣṭāṅga-yoga)

Read the complete Markdown/PDF for arguments, objections, PYQs and model answers.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Yoga - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session	4
BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION	4
RAPID REVISION 1 - Yoga as Theistic Samkhya (seśvara-sāṃkhya) and the Structure of Mind-field (citta)	4
RAPID REVISION 2 - Restraint of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha): Five Modifications and Real Transformation of Mind	4
RAPID REVISION 3 - Afflictions (kleśas), Action and moral consequence (karma) and Astanga Yoga: The Causal Therapy of Bondage	4
RAPID REVISION 4 - Meditative absorption (samādhi): Object-Supported Insight, Seedless Restraint and Classification Control	4
RAPID REVISION 5 - Isolation (kaivalya) and Lord (Īśvara): Isolation, Discernment and the Special Conscious witness (puruṣa)	5
RAPID REVISION 6 - Inter-School Debates, Realism, Criticisms and UPSC Traps	5
RAPID REVISION 7 - Advanced Ledgers, Comparative Positioning and the Graded Verdict	5
RAPID REVISION 8 - PYQ Routing, Current Linkage and Complete Exam Deployment	5
Integrated MCQ Loop - 24 Questions	6
Remedial MCQ Loop - 8 Questions	8
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE	8
EXAM APPLICATION 1 - Yoga as Theistic Samkhya (seśvara-sāṃkhya) and the Structure of Mind-field (citta)	8
EXAM APPLICATION 2 - Restraint of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha): Five Modifications and Real Transformation of Mind	8
EXAM APPLICATION 3 - Afflictions (kleśas), Action and moral consequence (karma) and Astanga Yoga: The Causal Therapy of Bondage	9
EXAM APPLICATION 4 - Meditative absorption (samādhi): Object-Supported Insight, Seedless Restraint and Classification Control	9
EXAM APPLICATION 5 - Isolation (kaivalya) and Lord (Īśvara): Isolation, Discernment and the Special Conscious witness (puruṣa)	9
EXAM APPLICATION 6 - Inter-School Debates, Realism, Criticisms and UPSC Traps	9
EXAM APPLICATION 7 - Advanced Ledgers, Comparative Positioning and the Graded Verdict	9
EXAM APPLICATION 8 - PYQ Routing, Current Linkage and Complete Exam Deployment	10
Workbook Use Guide	10
Solved PYQ 1 - 2019 Q7(b), 15 marks	10
Solved PYQ 2 - 2020 Q5(b), 10 marks	10
Solved PYQ 3 - 2021 Q6(a), 20 marks	11
Solved PYQ 4 - 2022 Q5(c), 10 marks	12

Solved PYQ 5 - 2023 Q7(c), 15 marks	12
Solved PYQ 6 - 2024 Q7(b), 15 marks	13
Solved PYQ 7 - 2025 Q7(b), 15 marks	13
Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks	14
Original Mains Practice 2 - 15 marks	14
Original Mains Practice 3 - 20 marks	14

Yoga - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

RAPID REVISION 1 - Yoga as Theistic Samkhya (seśvara-sāṃkhya) and the Structure of Mind-field (citta)

Rapid recall

- Yoga shares Samkhya's 25 principles (tattvas) and dualism.
- Mind-field (citta) is material-subtle; Conscious witness (puruṣa) is conscious.
- Reflection explains empirical cognition and misidentification.
- Yoga-fit states: one-pointed mind (ekāgra) and fully restrained mind (niruddha).
- Trap: high intellectual concentration alone is not final yogic restraint.

RAPID REVISION 2 - Restraint of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha): Five Modifications and Real Transformation of Mind

Rapid recall

- Yoga = restraint of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha).
- Then the seer abides in its own nature.
- Five vṛttis; each may be klista or aklista.
- Means: sustained practice (abhyāsa) and dispassion (vairāgya).
- Trap: nirodha is not destruction of consciousness.

RAPID REVISION 3 - Afflictions (kleśas), Action and moral consequence (karma) and Astanga Yoga: The Causal Therapy of Bondage

Rapid recall

- Root affliction (kleśa): ignorance (avidyā).
- Ego-identification (asmitā) confuses seer and instrument.
- Attachment (rāga) follows pleasure; aversion (dveṣa) follows pain; clinging to life (abhiniveśa) clings to life.
- Eight limbs move from ethics to absorption.
- Integrated concentration (saṃyama) = concentration (dhāraṇā) + meditation (dhyāna) + meditative absorption (samādhi).

RAPID REVISION 4 - Meditative absorption (samādhi): Object-Supported Insight, Seedless Restraint and Classification Control

Rapid recall

- Samprajñata: object-supported and cognitive.
- Asamprajñata: cessation with possible residual impression.
- Nirbija: even residual seed ceases.
- Rāmbhara prajña follows mature nirvicara.
- Trap: samapatti subtypes are not YS 1.17's four factors.

RAPID REVISION 5 - Isolation (kaivalya) and Lord (Īśvara): Isolation, Discernment and the Special Conscious witness (puruṣa)

Rapid recall

- Isolation (kaivalya) = isolation/self-establishment of Conscious witness (puruṣa).
- Path culminates in discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti) and supreme detachment.
- Lord (Īśvara) is special Conscious witness (puruṣa), pranava's referent and timeless teacher.
- Lord (Īśvara) is instrumental, not constitutive, in liberation.
- Trap: Yoga is Sesvara, but not creator-theism in the straightforward Nyaya sense.

RAPID REVISION 6 - Inter-School Debates, Realism, Criticisms and UPSC Traps

Rapid recall

- Samkhya supplies metaphysics; Yoga adds praxis and Lord (Īśvara).
- Yoga defends external objects against mind-only theory.
- Strongest area: integrated ethics and psychology.
- Weakest area: Purusa-Prakriti interaction and limited divine necessity.
- Trap: public wellness Yoga is not the whole Patanjala system.

RAPID REVISION 7 - Advanced Ledgers, Comparative Positioning and the Graded Verdict

Rapid recall

- Strengths: phenomenology, ethical psychology, practical sequence, meditative analysis.
- Weaknesses: interaction, limited Lord (Īśvara) role, verification of extraordinary claims.
- Best verdict: philosophically richer than exercise, strongest as a disciplined psychology of liberation.

RAPID REVISION 8 - PYQ Routing, Current Linkage and Complete Exam Deployment

Rapid recall - master route

Prompt	Recall spine
Mind-field (citta)	material mind-complex reflecting Conscious witness (puruṣa)
Vrtti	five forms; restraint through practice and detachment
Affliction (kleśa)	avidya-rooted causal colouring
Path	preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga) and eight limbs
Meditative absorption (samādhi)	supported, beyond objectification, seedless
Lord (Īśvara)	special Conscious witness (puruṣa) and contemplative aid
Isolation (kaivalya)	discrimination, involution and self-abidance

Integrated MCQ Loop - 24 Questions

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
1	Yoga is defined as: A. restraint of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha) B. union with creator C. bodily fitness D. ritual action	A	Patanjali defines Yoga as restraint of mental modifications.
2	Mind-field (citta) includes: A. Conscious witness (puruṣa) alone B. determinative intellect (buddhi), ego-maker (ahaṁkāra) and sensory mind (manas) C. gross body only D. five elements	B	It is the operative inner instrument.
3	The scientist in the PYQ is best placed at: A. dull mind (mūḍha) B. restless mind (kṣipta) C. distracted mind (vikṣipta) D. fully restrained mind (niruddha)	C	Strong but outward and intermittent focus remains distracted mind (vikṣipta).
4	Complete restraint corresponds to: A. one-pointed mind (ekāgra) B. dull mind (mūḍha) C. distracted mind (vikṣipta) D. fully restrained mind (niruddha)	D	Fully restrained mind (niruddha) is fully restrained mind-field (citta).
5	Root affliction (kleśa) is: A. ignorance (avidyā) B. attachment (rāga) C. aversion (dveṣa) D. clinging to life (abhiniveśa)	A	Other afflictions grow in ignorance (avidyā)'s field.
6	Confusion of seer and seeing instrument is: A. smṛti B. ego-identification (asmitā) C. nidra D. means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)	B	Ego-identification (asmitā) identifies Conscious witness (puruṣa) with determinative intellect (buddhi)/mind-field (citta).
7	Attachment based on pleasure is: A. clinging to life (abhiniveśa) B. ignorance (avidyā) C. attachment (rāga) D. aversion (dveṣa)	C	Attachment (rāga) follows remembered pleasure.
8	Instinctive clinging to life is: A. ego-identification (asmitā) B. attachment (rāga) C. aversion (dveṣa) D. clinging to life (abhiniveśa)	D	It persists even in the learned.
9	Preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga) consists of: A. tapas, svadhyaya, Dedication to the Lord (īśvara-praṇidhāna) B. ethical restraint (yama), observance (niyama), posture (āsana) C. concentration (dhāraṇā), meditation (dhyāna), meditative absorption (samādhi) D. means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa), viparyaya, smṛti	A	These attenuate afflictions (kleśas) and prepare meditative absorption (samādhi).
10	The fifth limb is: A. breath regulation (prāṇāyāma) B. sense withdrawal (pratyaḥhāra) C. concentration (dhāraṇā) D. meditation (dhyāna)	B	Withdrawal follows breath regulation.
11	Continuous flow of attention is: A. posture (āsana) B. concentration (dhāraṇā) C. meditation (dhyāna) D. integrated concentration (saṁyama)	C	Meditation (dhyāna) is uninterrupted meditative flow.
12	Combined dharana-dhyana-samadhi is: A. nirodha B. viveka C. preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga) D. integrated concentration (saṁyama)	D	Integrated concentration (saṁyama) is their integrated application.
13	Valid cognition is called: A. pramana-vṛtti B. viparyaya C. vikalpa D. nidra	A	Even truth is a modification of mind-field (citta).
14	Word-based construction without object is: A. smṛti B. vikalpa C. means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) D. meditative absorption (samādhi)	B	Vikalpa arises from words lacking corresponding fact.
15	Sleep counts as vṛtti because: A. it is meditative absorption (samādhi) B. Conscious witness (puruṣa) sleeps C. absence-cognition leaves a recoltable impression D. all senses act	C	Later recollection indicates a supporting mental mode.
16	Samprajñata meditative absorption (samādhi) retains: A. no saṁskara whatsoever B. creator-consciousness C. bodily motion D. cognitive object/support	D	It is absorption with prajna and seed.

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
17	Truth-bearing insight is: A. rtambhara prajna B. ego-identification (asmitā) C. viveka only after death D. savitarka	A	It arises from mature nirvicara.
18	Lord (Īśvara) is: A. Primordial material nature (prakṛti) B. puruṣa-viśeṣa C. material creator D. liberated mind-field (citta)	B	He is eternally untouched special Conscious witness (puruṣa).
19	Lord (Īśvara)'s verbal symbol is: A. Veda B. mahat C. pranava D. akasa	C	Om/pranava is contemplated with its meaning.
20	Isolation (kaivalya) means: A. union with Brahman B. heavenly enjoyment C. merging into God D. isolation and self-establishment of Conscious witness (puruṣa)	D	It is separation from guna-purpose.
21	Immediate liberating cognition is: A. discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti) B. sensory perception C. testimony alone D. memory	A	Stable discrimination separates seer and seen.
22	Dharmamegha meditative absorption (samādhi) is linked with: A. attachment to powers B. supreme dispassion and final removal of affliction C. ordinary concentration D. sleep	B	It culminates the path when insight itself is not appropriated.
23	Yoga differs from Samkhya chiefly by: A. rejecting Conscious witness (puruṣa) B. denying Primordial material nature (prakṛti) C. adding disciplined praxis and Lord (Īśvara) D. accepting monism	C	It is often called theistic Samkhya (śeṣvara-sāṃkhya).
24	Best doctrinal warning: A. Yoga is exercise only B. isolation (kaivalya) is union C. Lord (Īśvara) creates matter D. public wellness Yoga must not replace Patanjala soteriology	D	Contemporary practice and classical doctrine must be distinguished.

Remedial MCQ Loop - 8 Questions

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
25	One-pointed mind (ekāgra) means: A. one-pointed mind-field (citta) B. torpid mind-field (citta) C. fully seedless state D. error	A	It is Yoga-fit concentration but not complete restraint.
26	Which vṛtti is recollection? A. nidra B. smṛti C. vikalpa D. viparyaya	B	Smṛti retains past experience.
27	Afflictions (kleśas) in attenuated condition are: A. prasupta B. udara C. tanu D. vicchinna	C	Tanu means thinned through practice.
28	Asamprajnata is not sleep because it: A. contains ordinary dreams B. is caused by fatigue C. lacks discipline D. results from nirodha and transformative saṃskara	D	Its causal and soteriological structure differs from nidra.
29	First five limbs are generally: A. bahiranga B. antaranga C. integrated concentration (samyama) D. isolation (kaivalya)	A	They are external aids relative to the final three.
30	Yoga's Lord (Īśvara) primarily functions as: A. material cause B. aid to concentration and timeless teacher C. karmic sufferer D. universal substance	B	Patanjali's emphasis is practical.
31	Reflection theory says: A. Conscious witness (puruṣa) changes into mind-field (citta) B. mind-field (citta) is self-luminous C. mind-field (citta) appears conscious through Conscious witness (puruṣa)'s reflection D. both are identical	C	Mind-field (citta) borrows luminosity without changing Conscious witness (puruṣa).
32	Best overall verdict: A. Yoga is posture science B. meditative absorption (samādhi) alone automatically liberates C. God replaces discrimination D. Yoga integrates ethics and psychology, though dualist interaction remains contested	D	This captures its strength and central pressure.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

EXAM APPLICATION 1 - Yoga as Theistic Samkhya (śeśvara-sāṃkhya) and the Structure of Mind-field (citta)

Exam route

- **2019 Q7(b):** classify scientist as distracted mind (vikṣipta), God-centred devotee as one-pointed mind (ekāgra) and self-realized yogi as fully restrained mind (niruddha), with justification.
- Define mind-field (citta) as buddhi-ahamkara-manas functioning together.
- State that mind-field (citta) is not self-luminous and Conscious witness (puruṣa) does not literally change.
- Open broad answers with Yoga as **Theistic Samkhya (śeśvara-sāṃkhya) plus disciplined soteriology**.

EXAM APPLICATION 2 - Restraint of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha): Five Modifications and Real Transformation of Mind

Exam route

- **2023 Q7(c):** define mind-field (citta), list five vṛttis and derive why nirodha is necessary.
- **2024 Q7(b):** connect changing mind-field (citta), reflected consciousness, absent discrimination and Yoga's whole soteriology.
- Explain why means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) may be aklista yet remains a vṛtti.
- Distinguish nidra from disciplined cessation and asamprajnata meditative absorption (samādhi).

EXAM APPLICATION 3 - Afflictions (kleśas), Action and moral consequence (karma) and Astanga Yoga: The Causal Therapy of Bondage

Exam route

- **2021 Q6(a):** define all five afflictions (kleśas), their four states and the chain from affliction to action and moral consequence (karma), then show how removal leads to isolation (kaivalya).
- Explain preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga) as tapas, svadhyaya and Dedication to the Lord (Īśvara-praṇidhāna).
- Present eight limbs functionally: what disturbance each level treats.
- Never reduce posture (āsana) to the whole of Yoga or treat ethics as optional preparation.

EXAM APPLICATION 4 - Meditative absorption (samādhi): Object-Supported Insight, Seedless Restraint and Classification Control

Exam route

- **2020 Q5(b):** distinguish samprajnata and asamprajnata by support, cognition, samskara and function.
- **2022 Q5(c):** present the stages accurately and integrate Lord (Īśvara)'s instrumental role.
- State the two classification grids separately before showing commentarial reconciliation.
- Add the trap: asamprajnata is not automatically identical with nirbija.

EXAM APPLICATION 5 - Isolation (kaivalya) and Lord (Īśvara): Isolation, Discernment and the Special Conscious witness (puruṣa)

Exam route

- **2025 Q7(b):** define Lord (Īśvara) precisely, explain positive functions and state why isolation (kaivalya) still depends on discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti).
- Distinguish Yoga isolation (kaivalya) from Advaita identity and Nyaya's cessation-centred release (apavarga).
- Explain reverse evolution (pratiprasava) and establishment in one's own nature (svarūpa-pratiṣṭhā).
- Never write that liberation is union with Lord (Īśvara).

EXAM APPLICATION 6 - Inter-School Debates, Realism, Criticisms and UPSC Traps

Exam route

Use a dialectic grid: **opponent -> target -> Yoga reply -> residual force.**

High-risk checks:

1. Mind-field (citta) is not sensory mind (manas) alone.
2. Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) can be true and still be a vṛtti.
3. Nidra is not meditative absorption (samādhi).
4. Klista/aklista qualifies vṛttis, not afflictions (kleśas).
5. Lord (Īśvara) assists but does not bestow isolation (kaivalya) externally.

EXAM APPLICATION 7 - Advanced Ledgers, Comparative Positioning and the Graded Verdict

Exam route

- "Analyse" requires the causal chain from ignorance (avidyā) to action and moral consequence (karma) and release.
- "Critically examine" requires named objection, Yoga reply and remaining weakness.
- "Compare" should use means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa), self, God, causation and liberation.
- Best overall criterion: operational explanatory power versus metaphysical verification and dualist interaction.

EXAM APPLICATION 8 - PYQ Routing, Current Linkage and Complete Exam Deployment

Exam route

The complete practice section contains:

- **7 verified solved PYQs** from 2019-2025.
- **24 integrated MCQs** and **8 remedial MCQs**.
- Original 10-, 15- and 20-mark questions with model solutions.
- Final consolidated register notes after all teaching and practice.

Use current public-health Yoga only as a labelled contemporary anchor, never as doctrinal evidence.

Workbook Use Guide

Attempt each verified PYQ before reading its model solution. Then complete the integrated MCQs, remedial MCQs and original Mains practice. Correct MCQ options rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D.

Solved PYQ 1 - 2019 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question: How would Yoga comprehend the citta-levels of a scientist, a God-realized devotee and a self-realized yogi?

Model solution

Yoga classifies mind-field (citta) into five bhumis: **restless mind (kṣipta)** (restless), **dull mind (mūḍha)** (dull), **distracted mind (vikṣipta)** (intermittently focused), **one-pointed mind (ekāgra)** (one-pointed), and **fully restrained mind (niruddha)** (fully restrained).

Person	Citta-level	Justification
Scientist	distracted mind (vikṣipta)	capable of sustained empirical focus, but attention remains outward and fluctuates beyond the chosen task
God-realized devotee	one-pointed mind (ekāgra)	mind is one-pointedly established in Lord (Īśvara) and fit for deep meditation
Self-realized yogi	fully restrained mind (niruddha)	all vṛttis are restrained and the seer abides in its own nature

The scientist should not automatically be called one-pointed mind (ekāgra) merely because of intellectual concentration. Yogic one-pointedness includes freedom from ordinary attachment and a stable inward orientation. The devotee's concentration is supported by Dedication to the Lord (Īśvara-praṇidhāna). The self-realized yogi has crossed from concentration on an object to complete restraint.

Verdict: The hierarchy measures not intelligence but the degree of guna-purification and freedom from mental dispersion.

Why this earns marks: It applies all three cases precisely, avoids equating technical focus with yogic realization, and explains the governing criterion.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2020 Q5(b), 10 marks

Question: Distinguish Samprajnata Meditative absorption (samādhi) and Asamprajnata Meditative absorption (samādhi).

Model solution

Samprajnata	Asamprajnata
cognitive absorption with an object	cessation beyond objectifying cognition
supported by prajna and a seed	only residual samskaras may remain
includes vitarka, vicara, ananda and ego-identification (asmitā) dimensions	reached through supreme dispassion and nirodha
yields truth-bearing insight at higher levels	prepares for nirbija when even seed is exhausted

Samprajnata is not ordinary thought. Mind-field (citta) becomes transparent and takes the object's form with extraordinary clarity. Its detailed samapatti distinctions-savitarka/nirvitarka and savicara/nirvicara-must not be confused mechanically with the fourfold Yoga Sutra 1.17 scheme.

Asamprajnata is not sleep or unconsciousness. Sleep is itself a vrtti supported by absence-cognition, whereas asamprajnata results from disciplined restraint and leaves a transformative nirodha-samskara.

Why this earns marks: It distinguishes object, seed, cognition and residual impressions and directly removes the common sleep-confusion.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2021 Q6(a), 20 marks

Question: Explain the nature of afflictions (kleśas) and how their removal leads to isolation (kaivalya).

Model solution

Afflictions (kleśas) are afflictive structures colouring cognition and generating action and moral consequence (karma). The five are:

1. **Ignorance (avidyā):** mistaking impermanent for permanent, impure for pure, painful for pleasurable and not-self for self.
2. **Ego-identification (asmitā):** identification of seer with the seeing instrument.
3. **Attachment (rāga):** attachment based on remembered pleasure.
4. **Aversion (dveṣa):** aversion based on remembered pain.
5. **Clinging to life (abhiniveśa):** deep clinging to life, present even in the learned.

Ignorance (avidyā) is the field of the other four. Afflictions (kleśas) may be prasupta, tanu, vicchinna or udara-dormant, attenuated, interrupted or fully active.

ignorance (avidyā) -> ego-identification (asmitā) -> attachment (rāga)/aversion (dveṣa) -> action
-> karmasaya -> vipaka -> rebirth and suffering

Their removal is graded. **Preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga)**-tapas, svadhyaya and Dedication to the Lord (īśvara-praṇidhāna)-attenuates them. Eight-limbed discipline purifies conduct, body, breath, senses and attention. Meditation (dhyāna) burns subtle afflictions; discriminative knowledge destroys ignorance (avidyā)'s root. When afflictions (kleśas) cease, fresh karmic deposits stop, old seeds are exhausted or burnt, and mind-field (citta) no longer produces identification.

Meditative absorption (samādhi) alone is instrumental unless it matures into **discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti)**, uninterrupted discrimination between Conscious witness (puruṣa) and mind-field (citta). Para-vairagya prevents attachment even to insight and powers. Cloud-of-virtue absorption (dharmamegha-samādhi) completes the cessation of binding tendencies; the qualities (guṇas) undergo reverse evolution (pratiprasava) and Conscious witness (puruṣa) stands in isolation (kaivalya).

An objection says Conscious witness (puruṣa) was always free, so removal is unnecessary. Yoga replies that liberation removes misidentification in mind-field (citta), not an actual impurity in Conscious witness (puruṣa).

Verdict: Klesa-removal leads to isolation (kaivalya) by breaking both the cognitive root and karmic reproduction of bondage.

Why this earns marks: It defines all five, gives their states and causal chain, integrates preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga), astanga, meditative absorption (samādhi) and viveka, and answers the already-free objection.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2022 Q5(c), 10 marks

Question: Discuss stages of Meditative absorption (samādhi) and examine the role of Lord (Īśvara).

Model solution

Patanjala Yoga broadly distinguishes **samprajnata** and **asamprajnata** meditative absorption (samādhi). Samprajnata retains cognitive support and is associated with vitarka, vicara, ananda and ego-identification (asmitā). The samapatti analysis further distinguishes gross and subtle absorptions with and without conceptual admixture. Nirvicara maturity yields **rtambhara prajna**, truth-bearing insight.

Asamprajnata suspends objectifying cognition while residual samskaras may remain. **Nirbija meditative absorption (samādhi)** occurs when even the seed sustaining further mental emergence is exhausted. Dharmamegha marks the culminating cloud of virtue and complete dispassion.

Lord (Īśvara) is **purusa-visesa**, eternally untouched by affliction (kleśa), action and moral consequence (karma), fruition and latent deposits. Devotion to Lord (Īśvara), repetition and contemplation of pranava, and surrender reduce obstacles and accelerate meditative absorption (samādhi).

Verdict: Lord (Īśvara) is a privileged practical aid and timeless teacher, not the material cause or automatic giver of isolation (kaivalya); discriminative knowledge remains decisive.

Why this earns marks: It gives the stage architecture without conflating lists and evaluates Lord (Īśvara)'s exact, limited function.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2023 Q7(c), 15 marks

Question: Explain mind-field (citta) and its modifications. Why prescribe cessation of cittavrttis?

Model solution

Mind-field (citta) is the material-subtle internal instrument comprising determinative intellect (buddhi), ego-maker (ahaṁkāra) and sensory mind (manas). It reflects Conscious witness (puruṣa) and assumes forms corresponding to objects. Its five vrttis are:

Vrtti	Meaning
Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)	valid cognition
Viparyaya	error
Vikalpa	verbal construction without corresponding object
Nidra	sleep supported by cognition of absence
Smṛti	retention and recollection

Each may be klista or aklista. Even valid cognition is a vrtti because it modifies mind-field (citta) and can sustain identification, though aklista cognition helps generate discrimination.

Yoga prescribes nirodha because the seer mistakes reflected mental states for itself. Modification creates samskara; samskara generates further vrtti and karmic continuity. Through sustained practice (abhyāsa) and dispassion (vairāgya) this cycle is restrained:

vrtti -> identification -> affliction (kleśa) -> action and moral consequence (karma) -> samskara -> further vrtti
nirodha -> viveka -> non-identification -> isolation (kaivalya)

Nirodha is not destruction of mind or blankness. It is disciplined cessation allowing Conscious witness (puruṣa) to abide in its own nature.

Verdict: Cessation is prescribed not because cognition is intrinsically evil, but because unrestrained modification obscures the distinction between seer and seen.

Why this earns marks: It defines mind-field (citta), lists all vrttis, explains the samskara loop and gives a non-nihilistic account of nirodha.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2024 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question: Appraise Yoga soteriology in light of citta-reflection and self-identification.

Model solution

Yoga accepts the Samkhya dualism of inactive consciousness and active but unconscious mind-field (citta). Mind-field (citta) is sattva-predominant and transparent; it reflects Conscious witness (puruṣa) like a crystal reflecting a flower. It thereby appears conscious, while Conscious witness (puruṣa) appears to know, act and suffer.

Bondage begins when **ego-identification (asmitā)** identifies drk-sakti, the seer's power, with darsana-sakti, the seeing instrument. Vrttis become appropriated as "I think," "I desire" and "I suffer." Afflictions (kleśas) generate action and moral consequence (karma), deposits and rebirth.

Yoga's soteriology transforms the reflecting medium:

1. yama-niyama reduce moral disturbance;
2. asana-pranayama stabilize body and vitality;
3. sense withdrawal (pratyāhāra) withdraws sensory dispersion;
4. dharana-dhyana-samadhi produce one-pointed transparency;
5. discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti) permanently distinguishes Conscious witness (puruṣa) from mind-field (citta).

Isolation (kaivalya) does not alter Conscious witness (puruṣa); it ends misattribution. The qualities (guṇas) cease functioning for that Conscious witness (puruṣa) and return toward their causal ground.

The objection is that reflection presupposes a relation between ontologically separate principles. Mere proximity names rather than explains it. Yoga replies that all change occurs on the mind-field (citta) side; Conscious witness (puruṣa) remains untouched.

Verdict: Yoga offers a coherent therapy of misidentification, though its reflection model inherits Samkhya's unresolved interaction problem.

Why this earns marks: It translates the quotation, traces the complete therapeutic sequence and gives the strongest metaphysical criticism.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2025 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question: Explain the nature of God and its role in Isolation (kaivalya) in Yoga.

Model solution

Lord (Īśvara) is a **special Conscious witness (puruṣa)** untouched by afflictions (kleśas), action and moral consequence (karma), karmic fruition and latent impressions. He is eternally free, omniscient in the unsurpassed sense and the timeless teacher of earlier teachers. Pranava is his verbal symbol.

Lord (Īśvara) is not Primordial material nature (prakṛti), not one liberated Conscious witness (puruṣa) among others, and not straightforwardly the creator-God of Nyaya. Patanjali's primary interest is practical. **Dedication to the Lord (Īśvara-praṇidhāna)** weakens egoism, creates one-pointed devotion, removes obstacles and offers a direct aid to meditative absorption (samādhi).

Isolation (kaivalya) nevertheless consists in discriminative knowledge between Conscious witness (puruṣa) and Primordial material nature (prakṛti). God does not absorb the individual, grant union with himself, or replace citta-nirodha. His role is privileged but instrumental:

Dedication to the Lord (Īśvara-praṇidhāna) -> reduced obstacles and ego
-> deeper meditative absorption (samādhi) -> discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti)
-> cessation of guna-purpose -> isolation (kaivalya)

Critics ask why Lord (Īśvara) is needed if the Samkhya ontology and viveka already suffice. Yoga may concede that other routes exist while insisting that devotion is uniquely efficient and that timeless teacherhood grounds the transmission of liberating knowledge.

Verdict: Lord (Īśvara) distinguishes Yoga from nirīśvara Samkhya, but isolation (kaivalya) remains isolation of Conscious witness (puruṣa) through discrimination, not salvation by divine fusion.

Why this earns marks: It defines Lord (Īśvara) precisely, states positive and negative functions, connects devotion to isolation (kaivalya) and evaluates the redundancy objection.

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: Why does Yoga count valid cognition among the vrttis to be restrained?

Model solution

Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) presents objects truly, but it still modifies mind-field (citta) and can sustain identification: "I know." Yoga distinguishes epistemic truth from soteriological freedom. Valid cognition may be aklista and assist viveka, yet any object-form is still part of the seen.

The path therefore uses true cognition to remove error and finally relinquishes even the instrument when stable discrimination is achieved-like a thorn removing a thorn.

Verdict: Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) is not condemned as false; it is transcended because isolation (kaivalya) requires freedom from all citta-identification.

Why this earns marks: It resolves the apparent paradox and distinguishes truth-value from liberating finality.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 15 marks

Question: Is Astanga Yoga an ethical psychology rather than a sequence of exercises?

Model solution

The eight limbs form a causal architecture. Ethical restraint (yama) and observance (niyama) reduce interpersonal and intrapsychic disturbance. Posture (āsana) stabilizes embodiment; breath regulation (prāṇāyāma) regulates vitality and attention; sense withdrawal (pratyāhāra) breaks sensory compulsion. Concentration (dhāraṇā), meditation (dhyāna) and meditative absorption (samādhi) progressively unify cognition.

The limbs therefore transform habits, affects, attention and identity. Without non-violence, truthfulness and non-grasping, concentration may strengthen ego and affliction (kleśa) rather than dissolve them. Without the inner limbs, ethics remains good conduct but does not mature into direct discrimination.

Verdict: Astanga is an ethical psychology completed in meditative epistemology; treating it as bodily exercise severs the very mechanism by which it leads to isolation (kaivalya).

Why this earns marks: It explains the functional relation among all limbs and states why ethical preparation is philosophically necessary.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 20 marks

Question: "Lord (Īśvara) is indispensable to Yoga practice but dispensable to Yoga metaphysics." Critically examine.

Model solution

Yoga's metaphysical framework largely follows Samkhya: Conscious witness (puruṣa), Primordial material nature (prakṛti), qualities (guṇas), mind-field (citta), action and moral consequence (karma) and viveka explain bondage and liberation. Isolation (kaivalya) occurs through discriminative knowledge, not union with or creation by God. This supports the claim of metaphysical dispensability.

Yet Lord (Īśvara) is more than ornament. As puruṣa-viseśa he represents eternally unobstructed consciousness, grounds timeless teacherhood, supplies pranava as meditative support and makes surrender a powerful antidote to egoism. Patanjali explicitly presents Dedication to the Lord (Īśvara-praṇidhāna) as a route to meditative absorption (samādhi).

The strongest instrumental reading says other means-sustained practice (abhyāsa), dispassion (vairāgya) and astanga-can also lead to realization, so Lord (Īśvara) is a uniquely efficient optional aid. A stronger theistic reading argues that transmission of liberating knowledge and coordination of Puruṣa-Prakṛiti require him; later commentators expand this role.

The redundancy objection remains: if Lord (Īśvara) neither creates Primordial material nature (prakṛti) nor grants liberation, Yoga's distinct theism seems thin. The reply is that practical indispensability need not mean cosmological authorship. A perfect intentional object can reorganize mind-field (citta) without replacing its own effort and insight.

Verdict: The statement is broadly correct but too sharp. Lord (Īśvara) is not constitutive of the material ontology or formal definition of isolation (kaivalya), yet he is philosophically significant as exemplar, teacher and privileged technology of de-centering the ego.

Why this earns marks: It distinguishes metaphysical, epistemic and practical roles, presents competing readings and reaches a qualified verdict.
